▼ GLASSHOUSE



SKILL DEFICIENCIES

On January 12, the final day of the Viksit Bharat Young Leaders Dialogue 2026, Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** held a closed-door interaction with young leaders, exchanging ideas on India's future. Asked which ministry he would choose if he was not the PM, Modi named skill development. The choice was interesting, for a recent audit by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) of the Rs 12,000 crore flagship Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY) flagged serious lapses: 94.5 per cent of the beneficiary bank details were found fudged or unavailable; photos were duplicated, mobile numbers invalid; placement just 41 per cent; and enrolments blind to age, education and work experience criteria. Perhaps a pointed message for the minister in charge since 2024, the RLD's **Jayant Chaudhary**, to put the house in order.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ NOBLE PURSUITS

YOGI'S SOFT SIDE

The viral 'chips' exchange between Uttar Pradesh CM **Yogi Adityanath** and a child in Gorakhpur on January 15 was more than a social media moment. It reinforced a softer persona he has cultivated alongside his image as a tough, no-nonsense administrator. In recent months, the former instinct has kicked in: on January 1, the Lucknow house of an ill Anjana Bhatt was cleared of 'land mafia' encroachers within 24 hours of her meeting with Yogi; on November 26 last, differently-abled Khushi Gupta from Kanpur got the CM's assurance of support for her education and future. Beyond the symbolism, the official numbers underline the effort: between 2017 and 2025, the Yogi government apparently got 12,426 child workers back into school and provided financial assistance to 1,089 of their relatives.

